PART II

Time

Music moves through time. Underneath it runs a steady **pulse**; the pulse is grouped into **bars**; and every note and rest takes up a measured share of it. This part goes from that big picture down to the length of a single note.

1 **Pulse** — the steady beat underneath

›

2 **Bar** — beats grouped: 2, 3 or 4

›

3 **Time signature** — how many beats, and which note is one beat

›

4 **Note values** — how long each note lasts

›

5 **Rhythm** — the pattern of long and short

IN THIS PART

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Pulse and the bar

Under almost every piece runs a **pulse**: a steady beat, like a heartbeat or a clock. The speed of the pulse is the **tempo**, measured in beats per minute (♩ = 60 is one beat a second). Beats are grouped into **bars**, and the first beat of each bar is the strongest.

Strong and weak beats

BEATS IN A BAR	PATTERN	FEELS LIKE
2	**S** w	a march: left, right
3	**S** w w	a waltz: one, two, three
4	**S** w **m** w	most songs: a lighter stress on 3

S = strong · m = medium · w = weak

On the page

SIGN	NAME	MEANING
𝄀	bar line	ends a bar
𝄁	double bar line	ends a section
𝄂	final bar line	ends the piece
𝄆	repeat sign	go back and play again

How to count



Three bars of 3/4: the counting never changes, whatever the notes do.

Count every beat aloud, the same speed from start to end: "**1** 2 3 **1** 2 3". Say the bar's first beat a little louder. A metronome keeps you honest: set it slower than you think, and only speed up when a whole passage is steady.

WATCH OUT

- ✖ Speeding up in easy places and slowing down in hard ones: choose the speed of the hardest bar.
- ✖ Counting the notes instead of the beats: a long note still has its beats counted through it.

SEE ALSO Time signatures p. 40 · Tempo words p. 70

PRACTISE IT Workbook Level 0 · Pulse · Online: Metronome, Rhythm clock

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Notes and rests

A note's shape shows how long it lasts. Each plain note lasts **half as long** as the one above it. Every note has a **rest** of the same length: a silence, counted just as carefully as a sound.
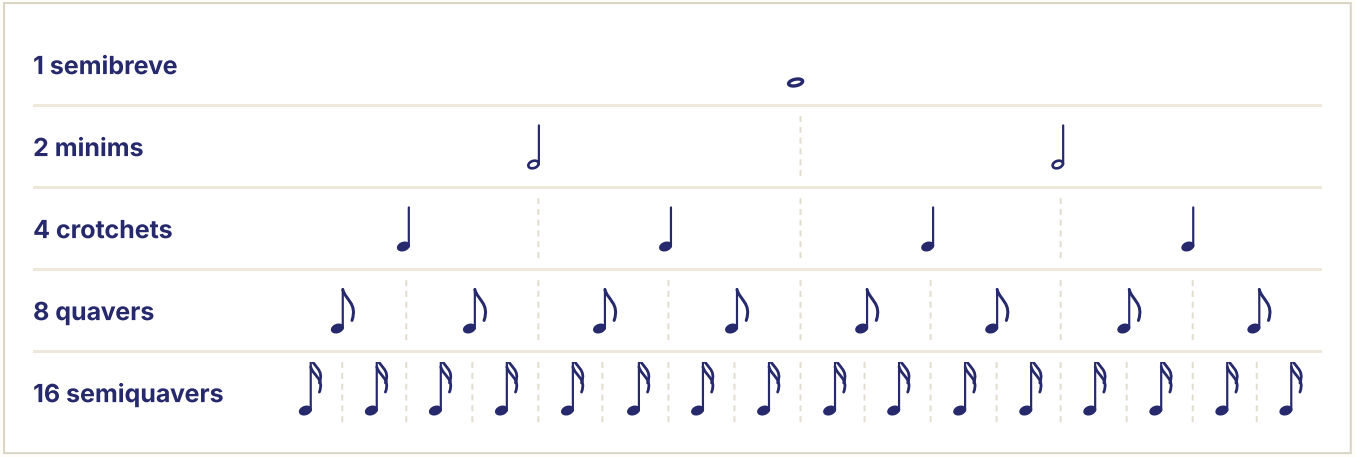
NOTE	REST	NAME	BEATS*	FIRST MET
		breve	8	Level 4
		dotted semibreve	6	beyond Level 8
		semibreve	4	Level 0
		dotted minim	3	Level 0
		minim	2	Level 0
		dotted crotchet	1½	Level ½
		crotchet	1	Level 0
		dotted quaver	¾	Level 3
		quaver	½	Level 0
		semiquaver	¼	Level 2
		demisemiquaver	⅛	beyond Level 8
		hemidemisemiquaver	1/16	beyond Level 8

* With the crotchet as one beat, as in 2/4, 3/4 and 4/4. The names used in the USA: semibreve = whole note, minim = half note, crotchet = quarter note, quaver = eighth note, semiquaver = sixteenth note.

PART II · TIME · 2
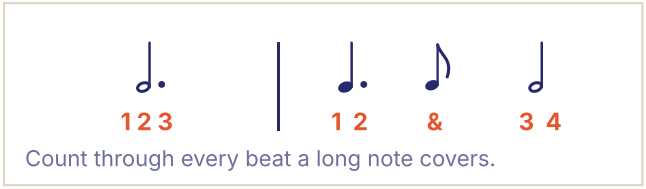
How long is a note?

Each row lasts exactly as long as the one above it: the same bar of time, cut into halves again and again.



The dot

A dot adds **half the note's value**. A minim (2) with a dot lasts 2 + 1 = 3; a crotchet (1) with a dot lasts 1 + ½ = 1½. A second dot adds half of that again.



Count through every beat a long note covers.

The tie

A curved line joining two notes **of the same pitch** makes one longer sound: play the first, hold through the second. A tie can carry a note across a bar line, where a dot cannot.

Tie or slur?

The same curve over notes of **different** pitches is a **slur**: play them smoothly joined (legato). Same pitch: tie. Different pitches: slur.

RESTS IN A BAR

A whole bar of silence is shown with a **semibreve rest** in the middle of the bar, whatever the time signature (in 4/2, a breve rest). Shorter rests follow the beats: in 4/4, two crotchet rests on beats 3 and 4 are written as one minim rest, but on beats 2 and 3 as two crotchet rests, so the middle of the bar stays visible.

SEE ALSO Time signatures p. 40 · Rhythm p. 44

PART II · TIME · 3

Time signatures

Two numbers at the start of the music. The **top number** says how many counts are in each bar; the **bottom number** says which note gets one count.

The bottom number

BOTTOM	NOTE	ONE COUNT IS A	FIRST MET
2		minim	Level 3
4		crotchet	Level 0
8		quaver	Level 1
16		semiquaver	beyond Level 8

SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?

In **simple time** each beat splits into two. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and splits into three. A quick test: a top number of **6, 9 or 12** means compound; divide it by 3 to find the beats (6/8 has 2 beats, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4).

Simple time: each beat splits in two

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
2/4	2 crotchets	Level 0
3/4	3 crotchets	Level 0
4/4 C	4 crotchets (C: common time)	Level 0
2/2 ¢	2 minims (¢: cut common time)	Level 3
3/2	3 minims	Level 3
3/8	3 quavers	Level 3

PART II · TIME · 3

Compound and irregular time

Compound time: each beat is a dotted note and splits in three

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
6/8	2 dotted crotchets	Level 1
9/8	3 dotted crotchets	Level 3
12/8	4 dotted crotchets	Level 3
6/4	2 dotted minims	Level 4
9/4 12/4 6/16	rare	*beyond Level 8*

Counting 6/8



Slow: count all six quavers. Faster: feel two beats, on 1 and 4 ("1 & a, 2 & a").

Irregular time: five or seven, in uneven groups

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
5/4	5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	Level 0
7/4	7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4	*beyond Level 8*
5/8	5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	*beyond Level 8*
7/8	7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2	*beyond Level 8*

The grouping can also change inside a regular bar: many dances, calypso among them, keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers **3 + 3 + 2**.

WATCH OUT

- ✖ Reading 6/8 as "six beats": at most speeds it moves in two.
- ✖ Mixing up 3/4 and 6/8: both hold six quavers, but 3/4 groups them in twos (three beats) and 6/8 in threes (two beats).

SEE ALSO Pulse and the bar p. 36 · Rhythm p. 44

PRACTISE IT Workbook Level 0 · Time signatures · Online: Library › Time signatures (hear each one)

PART II · TIME · 4

Rhythm

Rhythm is the pattern of long and short sounds laid over the pulse. The pulse stays steady; the rhythm moves around it.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS	FIRST MET
dot	adds half the note's value; a double dot adds half and then a quarter	Level ½
tie	joins two notes of the same pitch into one sound	Level ½
triplet	three notes in the time of two	Level 2
duplet	two notes in the time of three, in compound time	Level 2
anacrusis	notes before the first full bar (an upbeat); the last bar is short by the same amount	Level 4
syncopation	the stress falls off the beat	Level 4
hemiola	two bars of three felt as three bars of two	Level 4
grouping	beams show the beats: in 4/4 never across the middle of the bar; in 6/8 in threes	Level 4
swing	pairs of quavers played long–short, like a triplet	*beyond Level 8*
polyrhythm	two rhythms at once, such as three against two	Level 7
rubato	time given and taken back, for expression	*beyond Level 8*

Counting smaller values

NOTE	SAY
	1
	1 &
	1 e & a
	1 trip-let (or 1 & a)

WATCH OUT

- ✖ Rushing the short notes after a long one: keep counting inside the long note.
- ✖ Playing a triplet as two quavers and a crotchet: three exactly equal notes.
- ✖ Forgetting the upbeat: if the piece starts on beat 4, count "1 2 3" in silence first.

SEE ALSO Notes and rests p. 38 · Time signatures p. 40 · Words for how to play p. 70

PRACTISE IT Workbook Levels 0–4 · Rhythm · Online: Rhythm clock, Rhythm sheet